MONTHLY UPDATE

Uganda: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-28 · 83 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

Summary of the month

The month's largest single development was the close of an enforcement cycle rather than the opening of one. On 17 July 2026 the personal data protection office confirmed by letter that a foreign controller had implemented all five corrective orders from its February decision, within the prescribed timelines and with no appeal lodged. No fine was imposed.

Three regulatory campaigns opened alongside it — nationwide enforcement against unlicensed public Wi-Fi from 7 July, a national anti-piracy coordination effort on 17 July, and a ministerial statement of 31 July that attacks on telecommunications infrastructure are treated as economic sabotage. Uganda also took a seat on the African Telecommunications Union Administrative Council on 24 July.

The month closed with two announcements about instruments that do not yet exist: a policy to regulate artificial intelligence and social media, and a European Union funding window for a sovereign loan package on digital public infrastructure.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The ICT ministry states a device-tax-cut paper is ready for cabinet before the end of the quarter. The proposals behind it would take excise duty on data and airtime from 12% to 5% and VAT on mobile data from 18% to 14%, with duty relief on entry-level handsets; no measure is adopted and the study itself is not held.

Legislation and regulation

The regulator issued a public notice on 7 July opening nationwide enforcement against unlicensed public Wi-Fi providers under the Uganda Communications Act; no count of operators actioned has been published. On 23 July it reported a five-year sentence for vandalising a mast in Kibaale District, where damage was valued at USh23.6 million, and a one-year sentence for a SIM-registration breach; the minister of state for ICT stated on 31 July that such attacks are treated as economic sabotage rather than as offences against private property.

Data protection

The data protection office's letter of 17 July confirmed compliance with the five orders in its decision of 20 February 2026, which had required a data-protection impact assessment, an adequacy assessment, a legitimate-interests assessment and a Uganda-specific privacy notice. The decision imposed no fine and refused the complainant's prayers for cessation of intra-group sharing.

On 14 August the ICT ministry launched a three-year child online-safety campaign in Kampala with the communications regulator and a private partner. No budget, reach target or evaluation arrangement is published for it, which is the same gap that closed the previous awareness campaign without a measured result.

The sharpest test of the protection regime in the window came from another arm of the state. The revenue authority has issued more than 1,000 compliance notices since June 2026, and wrote to a commercial bank on 27 July seeking five years of customer bank statements, the directors' personal identity information and the bank-client correspondence, under the Tax Procedures Code Act and against a ten-month collection shortfall of Ush1.5 trillion. Nothing from the data protection office is on record about it.

Regional collaboration

Uganda was elected to the African Telecommunications Union Administrative Council at Abuja on 24 July, one of 25 member states for a four-year term. At a regional central bankers' meeting in Kampala the same day, the chair called for a harmonised East African framework for regulatory sandboxes covering artificial intelligence and digital finance; the meeting's signed communiqué records no such item.

Standards

On 30 July the transformation programme secretariat reported that its review of quarterly submissions under the fourth development plan found gaps and inconsistencies in the data ministries and agencies submit through the national monitoring and evaluation system, naming no error rate and no remediation date.

Public debate and participation in policymaking

The same day, revised media guidelines issued through the electronic court case-management system required prior accreditation, barred devices from a courtroom and made live broadcasting a case-by-case grant.

Reporting of 29 July recorded that no work had begun on the revenue authority's e-Tax2 procurement, whose technical evaluation the Appeals Tribunal set aside in October 2025 on a power-of-attorney defect; joint-venture staff have been on the authority's premises since January and none of 26 commercial banks would issue the performance guarantee gating the advance.

The month's set-piece was a convening rather than a decision: Internet Governance Week 2026 called for greater investment in digital skills, online safety and responsible artificial intelligence, and for Africa to move from consuming the technology to shaping it. Nothing was adopted, and no instrument on this ledger moved as a result.

Finance

MoUs and other agreements

The month's one cross-border approach is exploratory. A ministerial delegation visited the Ethiopian incumbent operator's headquarters in Addis Ababa on 13 August to explore cooperation on telecommunications infrastructure, digital payments, skills training and technology transfer, in support of the national vision and the 2023-2027 digital roadmap. No agreement was signed and no scope, value or timetable is stated.

New investments

The digital acceleration project is named as funder of the Tororo, Mbarara and Gulu service-centre pilots and as the affordable-connectivity vehicle. No disbursement figure is held for it.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

The regulator published sector figures on 2 July: about 47 million active SIM subscriptions and smartphone usage of 20 million devices, up from 18 million. The regulator's own quarterly report for the period to 30 September 2025 recorded 45.7 million active mobile subscriptions; both sets are compiled from licensees' submissions.

The second operator reported the same demand from the other side: 19.7 million customers at the half year to 30 June, up 10%, of whom 8.9 million take data, up 18.8%, with data traffic up 42.1% and average use per customer up 21% to 7.2GB against smartphone penetration of 46.6% — its own unaudited figures, and the first half-year series the base holds for it.

On 5 August the network operator with the largest published footprint released its 2025 sustainability report, recording for the year to 31 December 2025 24.2 million subscribers, population coverage of 96.2% 3G, 88.6% 4G and 19% 5G, 27,037 km of fibre and 45% of network sites on solar or hydro. These are the company's own unaudited figures and the base holds no prior-year comparator.

The largest mobile operator extended its group-level Starlink partnership to Uganda to bring satellite-backed connectivity to remote areas. It is distinct from the satellite operator's own licence, and no coverage target, site count or tariff is given.

Data Storage

The Namanve colocation facility is operating with no Uganda capacity figure published; its group committed capital rose from US$350m to US$380m on 13 July, a figure spanning seven markets rather than Uganda alone.

Energy

The largest operator's 2025 sustainability report puts 45% of network sites on solar or hydro, with a 490 kWh solar plant commissioned at headquarters. The figures are the company's own and unaudited, and no prior-year share is held against which to read that share.

Cybersecurity

The ICT ministry launched an updated national information security framework on 16 July, developed under the Uganda Digital Acceleration Project and setting minimum controls for government institutions, citing a 60% year-on-year rise in attacks including a UGX 62bn central-bank incident. The framework document itself is not published.

On 17 July the regulator opened work on a national anti-piracy coordination framework with broadcasters, three mobile operators, the revenue authority and the registration bureau. Legitimate pay-television subscriptions were given as about 800,000 in March 2026 against about 1.65 million in 2021. Dynamic address and name-resolution blocking is under exploration, and participants at the convening raised the dual use of blocking infrastructure built for piracy.

Two accounts in August put the threat above the response. A continental police assessment attributes over US$2m of losses to a single Ugandan deepfake investment scam, against 8% of intelligence analysts recorded as having advanced artificial-intelligence expertise and 94% of agencies as lacking digital forensics tools. At the communications regulator's first national cybersecurity conference on 13 August, an operator called for fraud protection to be built into digital-finance products and described an interface letting banks check for recent SIM-swap activity before processing a transaction; no uptake figure for the interface is published. The central bank separately told a conference that cybersecurity is now a national security issue.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

The identity authority put its own constraint on the record on 7 August: it is operating at 70% of its approved workforce, with 25 districts served by a single member of staff and two board seats vacant. The figures were given to the internal affairs minister alongside a request for a permanent headquarters and additional wage funding.

Four days later the Auditor General's account of the same authority reached the press, and it puts a size on the consequence. As at late October 2025 17 million citizens were still awaiting national identity cards, only 0.2% of first-time applicants had been cleared for printing, the staff vacancy rate stood at 26% and identity renewal faced a UGX256.8bn funding shortfall — reported amid cross-district queue chaos over collection of new cards. The figures are ten months old at publication, and the authority publishes no current backlog series against which to test them.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Three payment arrangements were opened in the month, all private. A licensed local-currency-in, stablecoin-out settlement corridor across four East African markets including Uganda opened on 16 July with no volume or counterparty figure published. On 21 July motor third-party insurance went on sale over a mobile-money channel with a digital sticker issued online, framed by the insurance regulator as narrowing the protection gap; no premium, policy count or target was published. On 24 July a bank and a payments company signed a memorandum on school-fees saving with payment-history-based financing, agent-network healthcare payments and digitised insurance. The signature date is unestablished, and nothing is on file about consent, retention or the legal basis for the credit-scoring layer.

A fifth put fares on a network. An operator and an electric bus company launched a cashless route in Kira Municipality, combining electric mobility, connectivity and digital payments, attended by the ministers for science and technology and for Kampala; no fleet size, fare, ridership or payment instrument is published. It is the base's first instance of public-transport fare collection being digitised here.

A fourth opened a settlement route rather than a product: a commercial bank integrated China's cross-border interbank payment system to offer direct yuan settlement to Ugandan businesses, against imports from China of US$3.3bn in 2025 and exports of US$118m. One bank's service, with no volume, fee or central-bank position stated.

The scale underneath all of it is in the regulator's quarterly report: 2.55 billion mobile money transactions in the second quarter of 2026, up from 2.37 billion in the first, on 59.5 million registered subscriptions, with telecommunications revenue at UGX 1.73 trillion.

A fourth arrangement opened on 19 August, and it is card rather than wallet: a commercial bank and an international scheme opened online acceptance of that scheme's cards to participating merchants in nine African markets including Uganda, settling in local currency, US dollars or both. The merchant count is given for the nine markets together.

Registries

The alien register issued its first cards. The identity authority began issuing Alien ID cards to legally resident foreigners, having enrolled 1,875 since registration opened on 10 June, with the US$100 card required for SIM registration, banking and business access but conferring no vote. About 2m registered foreigners are in scope and roughly 1.95m of them are refugees or asylum-seekers, so ten weeks of enrolment has reached under a tenth of a percent of the population the fee falls on. No waiver, instalment route or alternative for a resident who cannot pay is published, which leaves the card a precondition for a bank account and a SIM with no stated way round it.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

Electronic government procurement reached 136 entities onboarded with version 2.0 in service, verifying suppliers automatically against the revenue, registration, identity and social-security registers, and training opened for a further 100 entities on 3 August. An onboarded entity no longer advertises tenders in newspapers and may transact only with registered providers. Onboarding is stated to continue each financial year until all of government is on the system.

Two further e-services launched on 12 August under the same government network programme: a teacher-training platform with more than 6,600 teachers enrolled, and a case-management system for the Human Rights Commission. Neither carries a published retention rule or data-protection assessment, which is the sharper omission for a system holding complaint records.

Upstream of any of it, German cooperation tendered a consultancy on 5 August to identify and prepare bankable digital public infrastructure projects across Uganda, Kenya and Tanzania — identity, data exchange, payments and e-government — under the European programme with the East African Community. It is a procurement notice: it fixes the consultancy and nothing about any project it may produce, and neither its value nor its duration is stated.

The public procurement and disposal authority partnered with a budget-advocacy group to strengthen monitoring of government contracts. No scope, dataset or first published finding accompanies the announcement.

Technology

AI

On 30 July an external policy outlook recorded Uganda as still developing an artificial-intelligence strategy alongside a readiness assessment, sixteen months after the strategy was described as being in its final stages. On 2 August the minister of ICT told the Editors Guild annual general meeting in Jinja that the ministry is developing a policy to regulate artificial intelligence and social media; no scope, drafting stage, responsible body, consultation route or timetable was given. Editors at the same meeting raised data-protection exposure from digitised newsroom operations.

A profession got there before the state did. The medical and dental practitioners council directed medical and dental training schools to integrate artificial intelligence into their curricula, with compliance assessed at future biennial institutional inspections. No curriculum standard, syllabus, teaching-capacity assessment or funding is attached to the directive, and it lands in a country whose own strategy is still unwritten.

What developers here build on is being decided ahead of the strategy. A wire report records a Ugandan developer building a 31-language model on a Chinese open-weight model rather than an American one, largely on cost, against a claim in the same report that Chinese open-weight models took 17.1% of global downloads over the year to 15.8% for American ones. Neither figure is independently held here, and no licence terms or evaluation of the model are on record.

Crop-disease and precision-agriculture tools are being piloted under GAINAfrica, a Horizon Europe project led by La Sapienza in Rome and running in five African countries. No user count, evaluation or end date is published.

Innovation ecosystem

Three innovation programmes were opened or closed. The ICT institute launched the fourth and final cohort of a Japan-supported entrepreneurship programme on 22 July with 83 student innovators, publishing no cumulative startup, funding or job figure across the four batches. A recurring fintech convening opened on 13 July. On 3 August the minister of state committed to supporting commercialisation of innovations developed at the institute, with no budget, instrument, target or timeline.

Capacity

Training and skills

The state ICT institute reports 48,448 people trained in the financial year: 36,332 citizens, 1,932 government officers, 1,207 educators and instructors and 8,977 in immersive and emerging-technology skills, with 65 certified trainers produced. The figures are self-reported and unaudited, and fewer than 4% of those trained were government officers.

The IT authority invited expressions of interest for consultancy services to develop a National Digital Skills and Competence Framework. Nothing is yet awarded, and no scope value or delivery date is stated.

Inclusion

Access to services

At a readiness inspection on 27 July, six of nineteen planned one-stop service centres were recorded as operational, with three pilots funded through the Uganda Digital Acceleration Project and centre throughput made contingent on the fifth phase of the national backbone.

An ICT hub for persons with disabilities was commissioned in Kasese, reported on 1 August, offering computer literacy, vocational skills and digital-empowerment programmes and open to the wider community. No commitment value was published, so the base carries no finance record for it.

The commercial route to a connected device is credit. Buy-now-pay-later schemes run by five providers put smartphones in the hands of more than 500,000 Ugandans in a year, against about 22% of Ugandans using mobile internet despite 96% network coverage, with financed devices costing 30 to 50% more than the cash price. It is a trade analysis rather than a regulator series, and no default, repossession or total-cost-of-credit figure is published for the schemes.

A six-year donor digital-inclusion programme ended, with stakeholders urging the government to take over what it was doing. No successor instrument, budget line or transfer of assets is on file, which makes the closure a stated exposure rather than an inference.

Digital divides

A tower company remitted UGX 20.9 billion to the universal service fund, its statutory 2% of gross annual revenue, at a handover reported on 31 July. The regulator's executive director stated at the same event that half of that 2% goes to the Consolidated Fund and only half is retained to finance the fund, and put cumulative programme reach at laboratories in more than 1,000 public secondary schools. The period the payment covers was not published.

Money went the other way as well. An implementing partner's account of 12 August reports that work on connectivity and digital inclusion in Uganda slowed or stopped after the American aid wind-down of 2025, in which 83% of the agency's programmes were cut, the multi-funder Women in the Digital Economy Fund losing its American component while the parts other funders backed continued. What is described as lost is the convening as much as the money. No replacement funder is named and no Ugandan figure is given.

Data

National statistics

The statistics bureau commissioned 80 field data collectors on 4 August for the ninth national household survey, deployed in 16 language-based teams after fifteen days' training, for twelve months of collection. No sample size, budget, funder or publication date was stated.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The United States health-data memorandum is now held, and it is not the instrument the reporting describes. The signed text caps the arrangement at seven years, places it under joint steering-committee governance with Uganda as data owner, binds all activity to the Data Protection and Privacy Act and the national data-governance framework, and has Uganda approve the health information architecture before any United States-financed investment; planned support is US$1,719,960,000 against Uganda's US$577,001,796, including US$113,102,289 for data systems. It provides only for a future data-sharing agreement. A news organisation reported on 23 July that it had reviewed that agreement directly and that it grants direct, real-time login access to nine of Uganda's health data systems for seven years. The two accounts describe different instruments rather than contradicting each other; the agreement's own text is unpublished and not held, and no Ugandan or United States primary has confirmed or denied the account.

EU activities

A technical-assistance tender was published on 31 July, estimated at EUR 938,170 over thirty months from 15 September, performed from the regional secretariat in Arusha, with designs to be tested against the universal safeguards framework and against local data-protection and localisation law. The same tender names an added national funding window for a sovereign digital public infrastructure loan package with the ICT ministry, for which no amount, instrument or date is stated.

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EDITION	2026-08-28
CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/UGA/UGA-monthly.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.io/reports/UGA/UGA-monthly-2026-08-28.pdf
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